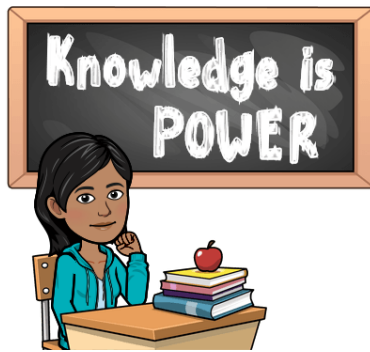




English Language Arts

Dr. Lacey Vasquez
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MSOS 2026-2027
Course Description

Welcome to English Language Arts (ELA)! In this course, we'll strengthen our reading, writing, speaking, listening, and thinking skills. We'll read stories by diverse authors, create our own written pieces, and engage in thoughtful discussions. ELA is a space to explore ideas, ask questions, and grow as critical and creative thinkers.

Please bring: sticky notes, pencils, a composition notebook, your computer, and a dedicated ELA binder. We will use Google Classroom and other edtech programs to support learning.

I am excited to learn and grow with you in this special place where we are empowered to succeed and guided by faith. I hope we can establish and fortify a strong connection between home and school, making this a stellar year!

Grade 8: Promotes ownership—students lead philosophical discussions and write across genres with confident reasoning, structure, and evidence.

Novels and Readings

Grade 8 ideas/resilience

The Pearl by John Steinbeck; *A Long Walk to Water* by Sue Park; *Hatchet* by Gary Paulsen

Great literature gives the reader opportunities to experience the human condition across decades and centuries. Great literature also has a compelling theme that is expressed through literary devices. We may substitute novels with short stories that have equal literary merit.

Types of Writing

At all grade levels, we will have at least one multistage writing assignment in each quarter: literary analysis, expository, persuasive, and argumentative writing.

Types of Speeches

Storytelling

Poetry Reading
Dramatic Interpretation
Research Presentations

Discussion Formats

Socratic Seminar (summative assessment)
p4C discussion circle (formative and summative)
Peer-to-peer
Table talks

Grade Categories

Homework 15%: at-home practice to develop the skills and support the content learned in class
Classwork 20%: daily grade– participation (when applicable), engagement, and seatwork
Quizzes 10%: short, formative assessment of particular content or skill learned in the course
Tests 15%: summative assessment of content and skills learned and practiced in the course
Portfolio 15%: student-maintained digital file to showcase excellent work
Projects & Essays 25%: multistage

Assessments

STAR Standardized testing
Timed essays
Socratic Seminar
Speeches
Multistage projects

Classroom Rules & Course Expectations

- +Stay in your seats.
- +Practice safety.
- +Use Computers and the internet for class purposes only.**
- +Be clean, tidy, and organized.
- +Be timely.
- +Be responsible.
- +Know all your assignments and due dates.
- +Be prepared.

No "Late Work" Policy

Students must turn in his or her assignments on the day it is due, at the time it is due. If you believe your circumstance or situation may be an exception, please contact me through email before the assignment is due. ***All late assignments will be subject to a 10% penalty. All late work must be submitted by the next school (not class) day.***

For work missed due to an absence: Students are responsible for finding out what worked they may have missed due to an absence.

Grade Scale

A+= 100%-97%
A = 96%-93%
A- = 92%-90%
B+= 89%-87%
B = 86%-83%
B- = 82%-80%
C+= 79%-77%
C = 76%-73%
C- = 72%-70%

D+ = 69%-67%
D = 66%-63%
D- = 62%-60%
F = 59%-0

Tips from the Teacher

- **Google Classroom:** Use your child's Google Classroom. Every student has a Google Classroom login. Ask for their username and login, so you can see the assignments and feedback they receive on Google Classroom.
- **PE Uniforms:** It is possible that students will misread their schedules and forget they have PE. Leave one set of PE uniforms at school in the classroom cubby...just in case.
- **Regular Uniforms:** It's always good to keep a spare polo in the cubby, too. Recess can be a sweaty event, and I allow students to change their shirts in the bathroom if they ask.
- **"Read with a Stutter":** Re-read. "Read with a stutter" is a phrase a former student came up with to describe reading in English Language Arts. If we finished reading a book, a story, or a passage, we read it again, and again, and again. Once is not enough.